The M.K. Stalin-led Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK) government is striving to give the state's temples a makeover and, in the bargain, give itself one too. A massive renovation plan is afoot for Hindu shrines, including the retrieval of encroached land. The state's Hindu Religious and Charitable Endowments (HR&CE) department, which oversees temple administration in Tamil Nadu, has been issuing eviction notices thick and fast. Budgetary allocations for conservation and creating pilgrim amenities have gone up manifold in the past two years.

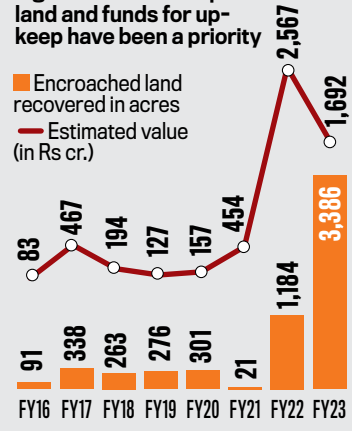
"Temples," Stalin had said at an HR&CE event in January, "are the symbols of our art and culture, their architecture an example of our artistic excellence. It is our duty to preserve them." In doing so, the Tamil Nadu chief minister is also hoping to present his party in a new avatar. Rationalism and social reform have always been at the core of the Dravidian movement, which has had such stalwarts as the atheist E.V. Ramasamy at its helm. The DMK, too, is a child of that movement. Addressing the concern that its ideology perhaps makes the party averse to religion, Stalin had added, "Those who lack reason criticise Dravidian tenets and say we are anti-religion. We are opposed to fanatics, not religion."

Spearheading Stalin's 'Hindu push' is the state's pro-active HR&CE minister P.K. Sekar Babu, a staunch believer himself. Under his stewardship, the department has not only undertaken the mammoth task of assessing the 45,809 temples and other Hindu institutions under its supervision, but also, as Sekar disclosed in the state assembly this March, ensured that in the past two years "encroachments in immovable properties belonging to 502 religious institutions have been removed and 4,501.8 acres of agricultural land, 809 vacant plots, 156 building grounds have been recovered. Some 132 grounds around temple tanks were also restored". The previous AIADMK regime, he said, had retrieved only 3,177 acres in the 10 years it was in power. The current initiatives, Sekar believes, have ushered in an "era of spiritual revolution". The new-found 'energy' is also finding acknowledgement. "The government and the minister have infused energy into a sleepy HR&CE department," says Karumuttu T. Kannan, a trustee of the 800-year-old Meenakshi Sundareswarar temple in Madurai.

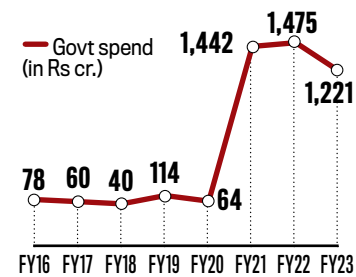
But what exactly are the contours of the DMK government's temple plans? To begin with, the department found that over 35,000 of the 45,809 temples under its charge, reportedly do not generate enough income to sustain themselves. As a result, 150 licensed surveyors have now been deployed now to survey and assess the temple assets. "They have covered 108,000 acres of the total 475,000 acres," says B. Chandra Mohan, principal secretary, tourism, culture and religious endowments.

THE FAITH AGGREGATOR

Since the DMK came to power in 2021, recovering encroached temple land and funds for upkeep have been a priority



CONSERVATION/ PILGRIMS' RELIEF WORKS TAKEN UP



A SACRED GEOGRAPHY

Modern survey technologies such as Differential Global Positioning Systems (DGPS) and Geographical Information System (GIS) are being used to survey land even as records are being digitised. The DGPS helps capture precise land boundaries and dimensions. The ground measurements are linked with geographical data attributes in a GIS format to create a digital database. All temple assets and land records will now be registered in the name of the deities to prevent individuals and other entities from usurping them. This should curtail the numerous cases of temple mismanagement pending in various courts.

Encroachments, though, remain a primary challenge. In September 2021, the state amended the Tamil Nadu HR&CE Act, 1959, to make encroachment of properties belonging to religious institutions a non-bailable offence. Anyone with an interest in the affairs of the religious institution could lodge complaints against encroachers. Sekar says properties worth Rs 4,226 crore have already been reclaimed in the past two years (see *The Faith Aggregator*).

The stock-taking of temples and recovery of encroached land apart, the larger concern is to ensure that all endangered temples—around 600 of them over 1,000 years old—receive regular maintenance. Archaeologists, conservation specialists and HR&CE engineers have already done an analysis of these temples. The government has set aside about Rs 100 crore a year for this restoration and conservation exercise. A corpus of Rs 2 lakh each has been set aside for 15,000 temples, the interest income from which can be used to meet daily expenses. "The Oru Kalai Poojai scheme offering a government grant to financially weak temples is a great move," says *sorpozhivu* (oral storytell-